

OLUWADAMILOJU OLUWADEMILADE BRANCO-RHODES

(06.01.1991 - 23.10.2024)

Born in Lagos on Sunday, the 6th day of January 1991, Oluwadamilaju was the second son and second child of his parents, Akintoye and OlaOluwa Branco-Rhodes.

He attended Corona Primary School, Gbagada. Upon completion of his primary education, he attended Aldro Prep School in Godalming, Surrey, England. He hated the weather and did not like schooling in England. He returned to Nigeria where he attended Grange Secondary school and later, three other institutions.

He joined the family business as Executive Director at an early age and rose to become the CEO of one of the strategic business units, Jubilee Estates Management Company. He held this position until his death. He was especially skilled in intelligence-gathering and had a knack of foiling offences before they were committed. Dami possessed entrepreneurial traits and was interested in real estate development and agriculture. He dreamed of building ecologically friendly smart homes. In line with his interest in agriculture, he started a poultry business and a fish farm. In 2022, Dami visited Rwanda in search of new business opportunities. Impressed by the ease of doing business there, he registered a Rwanda based company with the intention to return there within two years to commence business operations.

A keen observer of global and regional politics, Dami kept abreast of the latest developments in politics. From the American elections to the Middle East conflict to domestic policy, one could count on him for the latest updates and analyses. Dami was a devoted political disciple of his father, Akintoye. He accompanied his father on every political outing during his political campaign for the office of Governor of Lagos State in 2014. Members of his father's then political party, the Peoples Democratic Party PDP considered him to be his father's natural successor in politics and often joked that he was learning on the job. Dami secretly nursed the political ambition of one day becoming the governor of Lagos State. He had a strong sense of justice, equity and fairness and felt deeply pained at the prevalence of social injustice in the society. It was not unusual for him to break down in tears while watching news of tragic events occasioned by injustice, or sometimes, simply while driving on the streets of Lagos and observing the plight of the downtrodden masses.

Dami was raised by his parents in the Christian tradition in the fear and admonition of the Word of God. He sensed that he had a call of God upon his life that he would fulfil in due course.

As an infant, Dami was diagnosed with sickle cell disorder. However, the disease had little or no negative impact on him growing up. He led a normal life devoid of frequent hospitalisation. His parents attributed this to a miraculous healing he received as a baby when prayed for by Bishop Michael Reid of Peniel Bible Church, in Essex, England. As such, Dami did not suffer from bone pain crises. His health took a downward turn from 2017 when he suffered a raging infection which led to frequent hospitalisation

thereafter. Nonetheless, Dami would always beat the odds and recover miraculously in ways that left his doctors baffled.

As a child growing up in his family, Dami was greatly loved by his grandparents, parents, uncles and aunts, siblings, and cousins. He had a collection of nicknames and terms of endearment from different family members. His cousin, Mahdi El-dau, as a toddler could not understand how a baby much younger than him could be as tall as him, so he nicknamed Dami, "Damilohdu- giant baby"! His maternal grandfather coined several nicknames for him: as a baby, "Babi-Rho", an adaptation of Baba (old man) Rhodes. He grew to become a strapping teenager, six feet and two inches tall with a stately gait. This earned him yet another term of endearment: "Beautiful Walking Man" with the shortened form of "BWM". His immediate younger sister called him "Bobo" and his mother called him "Dam". As a son, he was a delightful, loving, and caring child from his early days into adulthood. As a brother, he was a friend and confidant.

Dami's life was punctuated with laughter. He took laughter everywhere he went and deposited laughter there. Additionally, he was extremely generous. His generosity was often abused. Dami obliged virtually every request for a personal loan, notwithstanding that he had a long list of previous defaulters.

Dami was a lover of fashion, music, and good food. He loved footwear and toyed with the idea of establishing a footwear line. His love for music transcended genres. He loved pop music, local music, gospel music and classical hymns.

Dami was the product of two prominent Lagos families. However, in forming relationships, he had no class restrictions. Dami made friends with everyone. He was class blind and social class was never a criterion for building relationships. Once during a minor surgical procedure, his surgeon reportedly told the rest of his team, *"this young man is a big man o. If you know the history of this country and the history of Lagos, you would know that this man who plays with all of you is a big man. Ebenezer Obey sang a song titled Board Members about his grandfather"*.

Dami was friends with everyone irrespective of class, social standing, rank, or position. Dami would walk into a shop or an office and in a matter of moments, would have made several friends. He loved and cared for everyone. He took on other people's pains and problems as if they were his own and did everything in his power to solve them, sometimes to his own personal detriment.

Dami found love in Bankeola Omoyele whom he affectionately described as his best friend. They tied the nuptial knot in an intimate wedding in December of 2021. Their union is abundantly blessed with Abifoluwa Ocean.

Dami leaves behind a legacy of love, laughter, and compassion.